on US air bases in Okinawa; this, however, was vetoed by Xi Jinping, in his role as chairman of the Central Military Commission (CMC). While American war planners did not know of Xi's decision, they anticipated the horizontal escalation of hostilities to US bases in the region and were surprised at the lack of enemy action against them.[36] For many Chinese postconflict commentators, Xi's decision not to attack Japan in the earliest stages of the conflict was a strategic error that prevented complete victory.

At this point, as intelligence about the aerial dogfight streamed into the US Pacific Fleet's Maritime Operations Center, the PacFleet commander sent orders to the US Seventh Fleet commander for the *Curtis Wilbur* to defend the *Bertholf* and disable any Chinese ship that interfered with ongoing rescue and repair operations. Similar orders went out to Pacific Air Forces to maintain steady air cover and intercept any Chinese fighter jets from entering a twenty-mile radius of the accident site. At the same time, he issued orders for all mission-ready Seventh Fleet combat forces to steam from Yokosuka, Japan, at full speed toward the Spratlys. This consisted of one cruiser, the USS *Antietam,* and three *Arleigh Burke*–class destroyers, making roughly twenty knots; in addition, a nearby nuclear-powered attack submarine was diverted to lurk in the waters near Scarborough Shoal. However, given that the additional US forces would not reach the Spratlys for close to a week, while the *Wasp* began the trip back from India, US firepower was limited to the *Curtis Wilbur*, with the ship taking up a visible position near Scarborough Shoal and the site of the clashes. To intimidate the Chinese, B-52s based in Guam commenced regular overflights of Chinese bases in the Spratlys on Wednesday, September 10.[37]

The American response was designed to sanitize the immediate area of the clash, but not to widen the theater of operations or prevent Chinese ships and planes from transiting the South China Sea, except for the area where the Americans were concentrating on rescue operations. This "minimum deterrence" approach made political sense but ultimately created opportunities for Beijing to take military advantage of US hesitancy.[38] President Newsom had been informed